

Call Center English Vocabulary

50 essential terms + 20 key word-pair distinctions



About the Trainer

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He works as an interview coach and educational content creator, helping Arabic-speaking job seekers prepare for BPO and customer service interviews with practical, real-world guidance. He also trains and coaches teams from a Learning & Development (L&D) perspective, translating real call-center experience into structured, teachable material for agents and new hires.

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آيات وأحاديث في فضل طلب العلم

وَقُلْ رَبِّ زِدْنِي عِلْمًا

سورة طه: 114

يَرْفَعُ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مِنْكُمْ وَالَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْعِلْمَ دَرَجَاتٍ

سورة المجادلة: 11

«وَمَنْ سَلَكَ طَرِيقًا يَلْتَمِسُ فِيهِ عِلْمًا سَهَّلَ اللَّهُ لَهُ بِهِ طَرِيقًا إِلَى الْجَنَّةِ»

رواه مسلم

«مَنْ يُرِدِ اللَّهُ بِهِ خَيْرًا يُعَقِّهِ فِي الْوَيْدَيْنِ»

متفق عليه (رواه البخاري ومسلم)

Part 1 — 50 Essential Call Center Terms

Short, clear definitions written for quick recall — ideal for interview prep and daily agent use.

#	Term	Meaning
1	Empathy	Understanding and sharing what a customer is feeling.
2	Sympathy	Feeling sorry for a customer's situation, without sharing the feeling itself.
3	Escalation	Passing a case to a higher authority to get it resolved.
4	AHT (Average Handle Time)	The average time an agent spends on one interaction, including after-call work.
5	FCR (First Call Resolution)	Solving the customer's issue during the very first contact.
6	SLA (Service Level Agreement)	An agreed standard for how fast a request must be answered or resolved.
7	CSAT (Customer Satisfaction Score)	A rating showing how happy a customer was with the service.
8	NPS (Net Promoter Score)	A score showing how likely a customer is to recommend the company.
9	QA (Quality Assurance)	Monitoring and scoring calls to keep service quality consistent.
10	IVR (Interactive Voice Response)	The automated phone menu customers hear before reaching an agent.
11	ACD (Automatic Call Distributor)	The system that routes incoming calls to the right available agent.
12	Hold Time	The time a customer waits, on the line, before being helped.
13	Rebuttal	A prepared response used to answer a customer's objection.

14	Objection Handling	The skill of responding calmly to a customer's doubts or refusals.
15	Active Listening	Fully focusing on, and confirming, what the customer is saying.
16	Rapport	A friendly, trusting connection built with the customer.
17	De-escalation	Calming down a tense or angry customer.
18	Churn	Customers leaving or cancelling a service.
19	Retention	Keeping existing customers from leaving.
20	Upselling	Encouraging a customer to buy a higher-value version of a product.
21	Cross-selling	Offering a related product alongside what the customer already wants.
22	KPI (Key Performance Indicator)	A measurable number used to track how well someone is performing.
23	Compliance	Following the required rules, laws, and company policies.
24	Script	A prepared set of lines an agent follows during a call.
25	Soft Skills	Interpersonal skills like communication, patience, and empathy.
26	Tone	The emotional quality carried in how something is said.
27	Probing Questions	Questions asked to dig deeper and get more information.
28	Paraphrasing	Repeating what the customer said, in your own words, to confirm understanding.
29	Dead Air	Silence during a call where nobody is speaking.
30	Wrap-up Time	Time spent finishing notes right after a call ends.
31	Ticket	A recorded case that tracks a customer's issue from start to finish.
32	CRM (Customer Relationship Management)	Software used to store and manage customer information and history.
33	Attrition	Employees leaving the company over time.
34	Shrinkage	Time agents are paid for but unavailable to take calls (breaks, training, etc.).
35	Occupancy	The percentage of logged-in time an agent spends actively on calls.
36	Utilization	How much of an agent's total paid time is used productively.
37	Onboarding	The process of training and integrating a new employee.
38	Coaching	One-on-one guidance given to help an agent improve.
39	Feedback	Information given about performance, meant to guide improvement.
40	Root Cause	The real, underlying reason behind a problem.
41	Workaround	A temporary fix used until the real problem is solved.
42	SOP (Standard Operating Procedure)	A documented, official way of carrying out a task.
43	Sentiment	The emotional tone a customer expresses, positive or negative.
44	Multitasking	Handling more than one task at the same time.
45	Patience	Staying calm while dealing with a difficult situation.
46	Assertiveness	Expressing yourself clearly and confidently, while staying respectful.
47	Objection	A reason a customer gives for disagreeing or refusing.
48	Value Proposition	The clear benefit a product or service offers the customer.
49	Follow-up	Contacting a customer again after the first interaction.
50	Closing	Ending an interaction, usually by confirming the issue is resolved.

Part 2 — 20 Word-Pair Distinctions

The pairs candidates and agents most often confuse — explained in one smart sentence, with an example that makes it stick.

Empathy vs. Sympathy

Empathy means you feel **WITH** the customer; sympathy means you feel **FOR** them, from the outside.

Example: "I understand exactly how frustrating that is" (empathy) vs. "I'm sorry that happened to you" (sympathy).

Customer Service vs. Customer Experience

Customer service is one interaction; customer experience is the customer's whole journey with the brand.

Example: A polite call is good service, but a smooth app, easy billing, and that same politeness together build the experience.

Complaint vs. Feedback

A complaint reports a problem that needs fixing now; feedback is an opinion meant to improve things later.

Example: "My order arrived broken" is a complaint; "Your app could use a dark mode" is feedback.

AHT vs. SLA

AHT measures how long one call takes; SLA measures how fast a company promises to respond overall.

Example: AHT: this call took 6 minutes. SLA: 90% of calls must be answered within 30 seconds.

CSAT vs. NPS

CSAT measures satisfaction with one interaction; NPS measures loyalty to the whole brand.

Example: CSAT: "Rate this call 1-5." NPS: "Would you recommend us to a friend, 0-10?"

Upselling vs. Cross-selling

Upselling offers a better version of the same product; cross-selling offers a different, related product.

Example: Upsell: a bigger data plan. Cross-sell: adding insurance to that same plan.

Churn vs. Retention

Churn is the customers you lose; retention is the effort and result of keeping them.

Example: A 10% churn rate means 90% retention that period.

Escalation vs. De-escalation

Escalation moves a case to a higher level; de-escalation calms the situation down without moving it anywhere.

Example: Escalation: "Let me transfer you to my supervisor." De-escalation: "I hear you, let's slow down and fix this together."

Active Listening vs. Hearing

Hearing is just receiving sound; active listening means processing it and responding to show understanding.

Example: Hearing: nodding while thinking about something else. Active listening: "So the issue started after the update, correct?"

Hold vs. Mute

Hold pauses the call and often plays music; mute only stops your microphone, the customer stays connected.

Example: Put a customer on hold to check a system; use mute to speak to a colleague briefly without ending the call.

Inbound vs. Outbound Calls

Inbound calls are made BY the customer to the center; outbound calls are made BY the agent to the customer.

Example: Inbound: a customer calls about a billing error. Outbound: an agent calls to confirm a delivery.

Script vs. Framework

A script gives exact words to say; a framework gives a flexible structure to follow in your own words.

Example: Script: "Thank you for calling X, my name is..." Framework: greet, listen, solve, confirm, close.

Objection vs. Complaint

An objection is resistance before a decision is made; a complaint is dissatisfaction after something already happened.

Example: Objection: "I don't think I need this plan." Complaint: "This plan didn't work as promised."

Attrition vs. Shrinkage

Attrition is employees leaving the company for good; shrinkage is paid time when staff are simply unavailable.

Example: Attrition: an agent resigns. Shrinkage: an agent is on a scheduled break or in training.

Occupancy vs. Utilization

Occupancy looks only at logged-in time; utilization looks at an agent's total paid time, including breaks.

Example: High occupancy means few gaps between calls; utilization also factors in time away from the queue.

Coaching vs. Feedback

Feedback is a comment on past performance; coaching is an ongoing process that uses feedback to build a skill.

Example: Feedback: "You interrupted the customer twice." Coaching: weekly sessions practising active listening.

Root Cause vs. Workaround

A root cause is the real reason a problem exists; a workaround is a temporary patch while the real fix is pending.

Example: Root cause: a system bug. Workaround: manually re-entering the data until the bug is fixed.

Assertive vs. Aggressive

Assertive means firm and respectful; aggressive means forceful and disrespectful.

Example: Assertive: "I can't approve that, but here's what I can do." Aggressive: "That's not my problem, deal with it."

Tone vs. Words

Words are what you say; tone is how you say it, and it often affects the customer more than the words themselves.

Example: The words "I can help you" said flatly land very differently than the same words said warmly.

Ticket vs. Case

A ticket usually tracks a single request or task; a case can bundle multiple tickets around one bigger issue.

Example: Ticket: "Reset password." Case: "Account security investigation" containing several related tickets.